

Goodbye gladiators

As more and more Romans began to reject their gods for the Christian god, people also grew unhappy with the brutal games still being staged at the Colosseum.

In 326 CE, Constantine decided to put an end to criminals being condemned to fight to the death in the arena—but that wasn't the end of gladiators altogether. Constantine still allowed people to celebrate his rule with gladiatorial games. However, the "golden age" of gladiators had come to an end.

By 391 CE, under Emperor Theodosius, all forms of pagan (pre-Christian) sacrifice had been banned and temples to

the old gods closed. Then, in 399 CE, the gladiatorial schools were shut down by Emperor Honorius. The final nail in the gladiators' coffin came in about 400 CE. The story goes that Almachius, a Christian monk, ran into the Colosseum's arena and tried to separate two gladiators. He was killed either by the angry crowd or by the gladiators on the orders of the Roman officials. Honorius was so disgusted by this that he banned gladiator shows forever, although animal hunts carried on for another 200 years.

THE ABANDONED COLOSSEUM BECAME A RUIN. ITS STONES WERE CARTED AWAY TO MAKE NEW BUILDINGS ELSEWHERE IN ROME.

